

Session 2: Proliferation and Oppression

Key Takeaways

- Exodus 1 is littered with vocabulary recalling themes from Genesis.
- Pharaoh, who considers himself a god, inverts the human vocation of being an image bearer who rules with justice and wisdom.
- From the first chapter, Exodus highlights the role of women in resisting injustice.

Creation Echoes

Genesis 1:28 Instructor's Translation

Be fruitful [prh] and multiply [rbh], fill [ml'] the land ['rş] and subdue it. Rule over the fish of the sea and over birds of the heavens and over every living creature that roams upon the land.

Exodus 1:7 Instructor's Translation

But the children of Israel were fruitful [prh] and they swarmed [şrş; cf. Gen. 1:20-21; 9:7] and they increased [rbh] and became very, very [m'd; Gen. 1:31] numerous, and the land ['rş] was filled [ml'] with them.

Note that in Genesis 1:28, humans are to rule over the fish, birds, and other living creatures. Humans are not commanded to rule over other humans.

Pharaoh's Fear

Pharaoh identifies a challenge to his control—the Israelites outnumber his people ([Exod. 1:9](#)). His solution is to keep them from multiplying so that they will not fight him and leave ([Exod. 1:10](#)).

His plan to solve this problem takes three forms: harsh labor, murderous midwives, and Nile drowning.

In this chapter, pay attention to who is named and who is not. The Hebrew midwives are named ([Exod. 1:15](#)), even though Pharaoh is not. The midwives' courage in defying Pharaoh is remembered for all time.

Come, Let Us

Pharaoh repeats the arrogance of the brick makers in [Genesis 11](#), whose city and tower tried to establish their own fame and avoid being “scattered” ([Gen. 11:3-4](#)). God has already demonstrated his commitment to opposing the proud. In response, God will reverse ([Exod. 6:1](#)) Pharaoh's oppressive policies ([Exod. 5:12](#)).

Store Cities

The building of *מִסְכְּנוֹת* (*mishkenot*) in Exodus 1:11 mirrors the building of the *מִשְׁכָּן* (*mishkan*, the tabernacle) in Exodus 25-40. These were likely warehouses with supplies for Pharaoh's funerary cult, ensuring that Egyptians would worship him long after his death. YHWH calls the people to build a tabernacle to worship him instead.

Reflection Question

Reflect on the vocabulary links between Exodus 1 and earlier Genesis stories. How would you describe the way that Exodus 1 recalls earlier stories?